

Chapter 22: No Longer Just a Customer

The silence after her words didn't disappear.

It stayed.

Not heavy.

Not awkward.

Just... present.

Like something had finally settled into place that neither of them could pretend wasn't there anymore.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

She suddenly felt very aware of her hands.

Her breathing.

The space between them.

Austin was still standing.

Still watching her.

Not with pressure.

Not with expectation.

With something quieter.

Something more careful.

Jenny broke first.

"Don't look at me like that," she muttered.

"Like what?"

"Like I just said something important."

A faint pause.

Then Austin said softly,

"You did."

That made her look away immediately.

Of course it did.

Behind them, the restaurant kept moving.

Orders.

Dishes.

Noise.

Life pretending nothing had changed.

But Jenny knew it had.

Everything felt slightly off-balance now.

"You're not going to make this easy, are you?" she asked.

Austin didn't hesitate.

"No."

That honesty again.

Always direct.

Always unsettling.

Jenny let out a short breath.

"I don't know what happens now."

"I do."

That made her look up sharply.

"You do?"

Austin nodded once.

"Yes."

"And what is it?"

A pause.

Not hesitation.

Just certainty forming into words.

"Now," he said quietly, "I stay closer."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not an answer."

"It is the beginning of one."

Silence.

Jenny crossed her arms again.

Instinct.

Defense.

Habit.

"This is still a restaurant," she said.

"I know."

"I still work here."

"I know."

"You can't just—" she stopped herself.

Because she didn't even know what she was trying to say.

Austin stepped slightly closer.

Not invading.

Just closing the distance enough that she couldn't ignore him.

"I'm not trying to take anything from you," he said.

Jenny looked at him.

"You already took my peace," she said quietly.

That should have sounded like an accusation.

It didn't.

It sounded like truth.

Austin paused.

Then—

"I think I gave you something too."

Jenny blinked.

"...What?"

He studied her for a moment.

Then said simply,

"A reason to stop pretending you don't feel anything at all."

Jenny's heart skipped.

She hated that he was right.

But she didn't answer.

Not yet.

Because answering meant stepping fully into something she couldn't step back from cleanly.

And she wasn't ready for that level of certainty.

Not yet.

So she changed direction.

"What does 'closer' mean to you?" she asked.

Austin didn't miss the shift.

But he accepted it.

"For now," he said, "it means I stop treating this like something that only happens inside this restaurant."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"...Outside too?"

"Yes."

That word landed differently.

Outside.

Her life wasn't just this place.

It was small apartment rooms.

Early mornings.

Late nights.

Family calls she couldn't ignore.

A world he didn't belong in.

At least... she thought he didn't.

Jenny narrowed her eyes slightly.

"You don't know what my outside looks like."

"I want to."

"That's not the same thing as belonging there."

Austin nodded once.

"I know."

A pause.

Then quieter—

"But I still want to try."

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

That word again.

Try.

Not assume.

Not decide.

Try.

Behind them, Bao was definitely listening again.

Jenny didn't even need to look.

She could feel it.

She sighed.

"This is going to be a problem," she muttered.

Austin's expression softened slightly.

"Yes."

"You're agreeing a lot today."

"I don't want to fight you."

Jenny shot him a look.

"You kind of always fight me."

"That was before I understood what I was fighting for."

That made her stop.

She looked at him properly again.

There it was.

That shift.

Not obsession.

Not arrogance.

Something steadier.

Something that had chosen direction.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"You're serious about this."

"I've been serious," he corrected.

She hesitated.

Then said quietly,

"I don't know how to do this."

Austin nodded.

"I don't either."

That surprised her.

"You don't?"

"No."

A pause.

Then—

"But I know I don't want to go back to before."

Jenny looked down for a second.

Then back up.

"Before what?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then softly—

"Before you."

Silence.

Not dramatic.

Not loud.

Just real.

Jenny felt her throat tighten slightly.

She didn't have a quick reply.

So she did the only thing she could manage.

She turned back toward the kitchen.

"I have work," she said.

Austin didn't stop her.

But his voice followed her anyway.

Calm.

Certain.

No longer distant.

"Jenny."

She paused.

Didn't turn.

"Yes?"

A beat.

Then—

"I'll see you after."

Not a question.

Not a promise.

Just fact.

And for the first time...

Jenny didn't correct him.

She just walked away.

And let it be real.